

Summary of Atlantic Sea Scallop Community Engagement Meeting

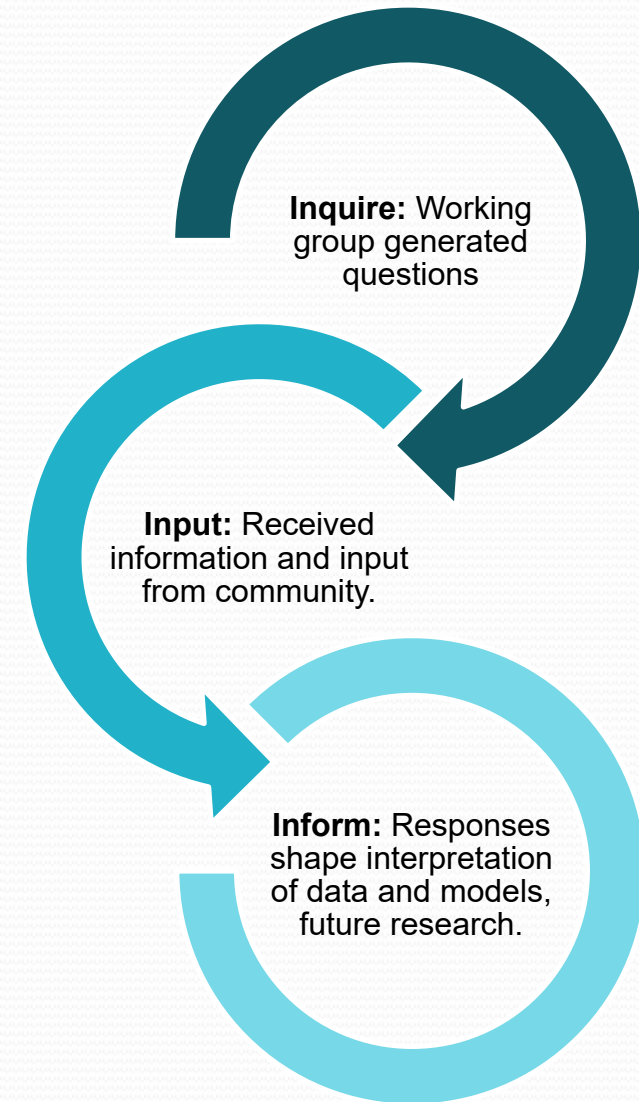
December 18, 2024
New Bedford, MA and Webinar

Research Track Peer Review
Woods Hole, MA
April 21 – 24, 2025



Focus of Meeting

- Working group developed a series of discussion questions (next two slides).
- Questions focused on effects of environmental change on the resource, disease and predators, and fishing behavior in response to management.





Discussion Questions:

1. Have you noticed any changes in the condition or mortality events? Inshore versus offshore areas? Have you been fishing in deeper water in recent years?
2. Have you noticed any changes in the timing of better meat yields versus the past? And if so: What do you think is causing this? Where are you observing these differences? Are there environmental factors that you think could contribute to this?
3. Have you noticed any changes to when scallops are spawning or appear to have spawned? If so, where did you observe this?
4. Which predators on scallops do you think are most important? Have you observed changes in the types, quantity, or location of these predators?



Discussion Questions:

5. How has management influenced your decisions on when and where to fish? What changes to your fishing practices have you implemented over the past few years (e.g., in the last 5 years)?
6. Would you say that the prevalence of nematodes and shell blister is increasing or decreasing? How much discarding is happening in the cutting box due to meat quality issues, and has this changed over time? Are there other meat quality or disease issues of concern?
7. Thoughts on performance of projection model and trying to predict scallops in an area at the end of its lifecycle. How can we improve? What is the rate of decline when conditions change? Year over year, how has our management worked?

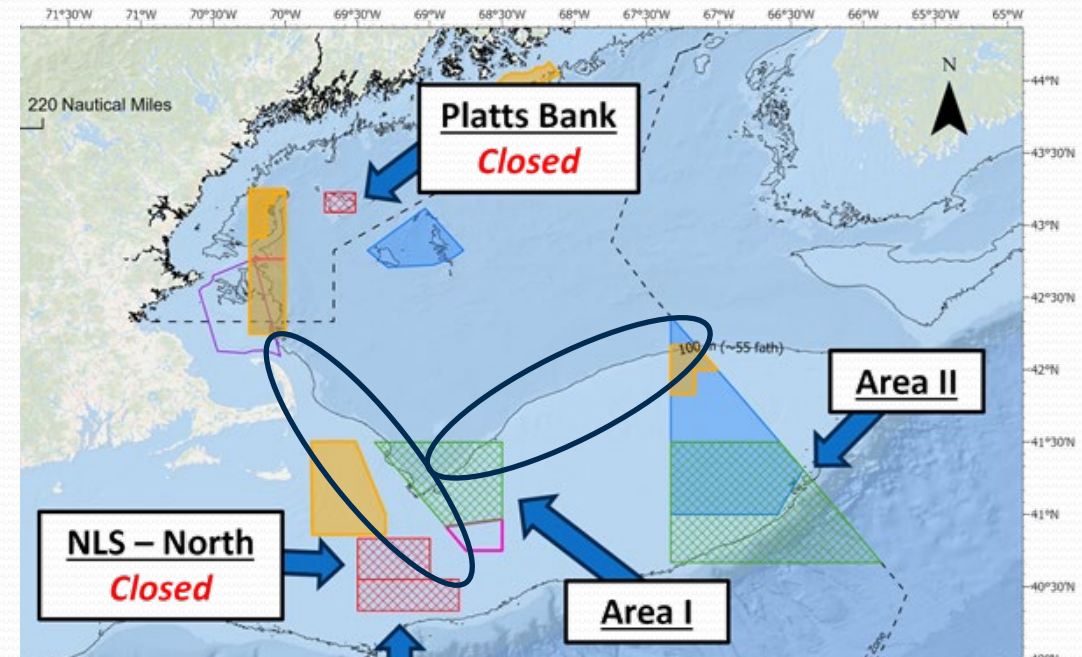
Session Overview

- Community Engagement Meeting occurred on Wednesday, December 18, 2024 in New Bedford, MA and by webinar. Hosted jointly by the New England Fishery Management Council and Northeast Fisheries Science Center.
- Presentation by Dr. Dvora Hart and Dr. Pat Sullivan on overview of Scallop Research Track Assessment followed by opportunity for input by topic, and fishing region.
- Fishermen and members of the community were encouraged to participate.
- ~85 attendees (online and in-person), comprising Scallop RTWG members, Council staff, fishermen, industry representatives, and other community members.

Timing and Quality of Meat Yields

- **Key Issues/Observations:**

- Interannual unpredictability in meat yields.
- Weaker and smaller meats becoming more common.
- **Area II of Georges Bank:** Significant week-to-week variability in meat yields.
- **GSC & Northern Flank:** Meat yield did not improve at any point during the season in 2024.





Changes in Scallop Abundance and Condition

- **Key Issues/Observations:**

- **Mid-Atlantic and New York Bight:** Limited productivity, with no observed seasonal improvements in meat yield or abundance.
- Resource depletion in rotational access areas.
- Fishing practices negatively affecting juvenile scallop survival.
- **Area II:** Decline in larger scallops (after being fished several years).

- **Suggestions**

- Using auction data as a real-time source of information.

Changes in Spawning Patterns

Key Issues/Observations:

- Underdeveloped gonads more common.
- Fewer observations of healthy-looking gonads.
- No signs of exceptional recruitment in 2024 reported.



Predator Impacts



- **Key Issues/Observations:**
 - **Georges Bank:** Notable increase in sea star numbers (*Astropecten sp.*)
 - Moving to warmer/shallower waters
 - Mortality is specific to juveniles, rather than adults
- **Suggestions:**
 - Explore more targeted predator control methods.
 - Use Vessel Trip Reports (VTRs) to monitor predator impacts and share data

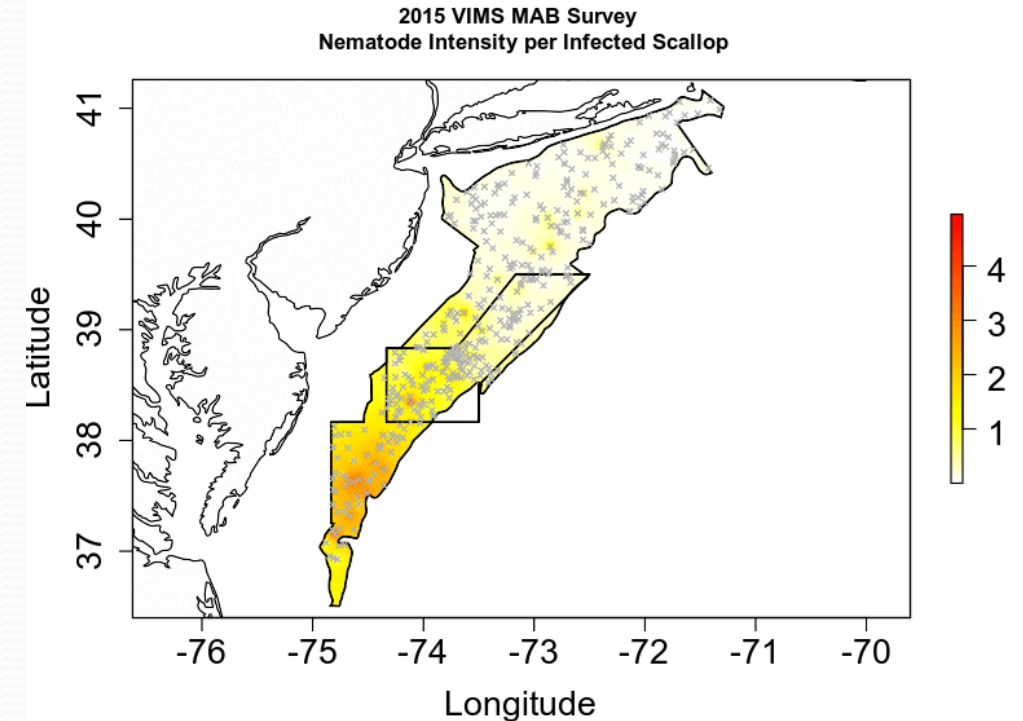
Disease and Meat Quality Issues

- **Key Issues/Observations:**

- **Mid-Atlantic:** Nematodes and shell blister disease remain persistent -> moving north.
- **New York Bight:** High discards due to poor meat quality in 2024.

- **Suggestions:**

- Further research into effect of wind farms on scallop health and distribution.
- Strengthen data collection on disease prevalence and impacts.





Projection Model Performance

- **Key Issues/Observations:**

- Models fail to account for decline in scallop abundance due to shifts in environmental conditions and intense localized fishing
- Concerns about performance of models in areas nearing end of rotational access

- **Suggestions:**

- Incorporate real-time field data
- Study habitat recovery rates of fished areas. How quickly do access areas recover after closing?
- Enhance collaboration between scientists and fishermen



Management Influence on Fishing Practices

- **Key Issues/Observations:**

- Pressure to fishing during months with suboptimal meat yield/quality.
- **Area II:** Gear conflict with offshore lobster fleet.
- Rotational management criticized for creating concentrated fishing pressure specific areas. Allocating too many boats to small areas.

- **Suggestions**

- Adjust management to allow fishing during more favorable months.
- Resolve gear conflicts.